



This is a book of young people's experiences during the outbreak of COVID-19 in Rwanda.



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SPECIAL THANKS TO:



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COVID 19 OUTBREAK

INTRODUCTION

In 2019 the world become aware of a new kind of pandemic virus called corona virus, after few months of its existence, the virus spreads to the entire world at high speed therefore all aspect of life was interrupted including in Rwanda.

The stake was very high both government and civil society faced a high risk which requested strong measure to be implemented as means of controlling its spread in order to protect the population. Lockdown was the first taken solution where people stayed at home and leaved when they went for emergency and necessary services.

The ideas of writing this book was inspired by Authors from English Corner Workshop at Club Rafiki after writing other two story books which are Rise of hope and shining dreams. Authors would like to share with you their outbreak on COVID-19.





DIFFICULT PERIOD

During lockdown life was absolutely difficult due to the unexpected life condition. We didn't have enough money to buy food at home, all the money saved by my mother could only brought food to last only for four days. Nobody was allowed to leave the house for no apparent reason apart going to the market or hospital, if there is no movement of people there is no activities to sustain our lives.

My mother relayed on asking people a hand out, although government tried it best to help vulnerable people with little food, but it wasn't enough because many people depended on that help! My mother's eyes had sadness the way I never seen before. I thought her biggest worry was to see us hungry. All doors were closed to us! We couldn't be paid money from a small room in our yard because the tenant was also in lockdown.

I finally realized that the whole country is passing through difficult period.

I wished things could become normal again as it used to be.

Chris KWIZERA

Saving is very
important





SAD ANNOUNCEMENT

As a young girl with a vision, I am passionate in studies, I have been enjoying being at school and having fun with my classmate. One day I heard unforgettable sad news due to the announcement of Covid-19, it was announced that school will be shut down next day until further notice, stay at home without going at school shocked me, I couldn't stand that. It was really sad but the comfort came back when the decision of studying via television and radio was announced, to me it was a relief far better than watching other programs.

There is a big difference from my normal class, I can't see my classmates and when I don't understand, — and I can't asking a question. Anyway the challenges and thrill I face during quizzes and exams are no longer there.

“School will resume again in September 2020 and there won't be any promotion!” a sad announcement came few days later that I have to remain in the same class! Fact is understandable. I would like to advise youth especially young girls to not waste their time by seating at home doing nothing, watching unnecessary TV and Radio programs or movies, they should use their time studying and doing some household works such as learning how to cook new dishes etc..

Divine MUSANABERA

You have to learn household works





DREAM INTERRUPTED

I am in senior three, my dream was to finish high school in 2023 but it happen because my dream was interrupted when I heard about covid-19. We were told that Covid-19 is in our country then the government decided to close all schools until September 2020. We made-up to go back home while we were still attending classes. It was a trouble moment and since Lockdown started, our daily lives at home have changed too, but we have taken a new line of attack.

As a student, I revise my studies while helping my parents with house chores around the house, I read different books, I have time to talk to my parents and receive some advice on how to avoid early pregnancy which is one of the problems destroying girls' dream. I also avoid unnecessary travels, I wear face mask whenever I go out, I respect social distancing wherever I am and I usually use hand sanitizer to kill bacteria to prevent the spread of covid-19.

Let me say that the best way to avoid boredom during corona virus outbreak is to use our precious time to help at home and to benefit from some educational programs provided by the government via different platforms such as Television or radio programs, it keeps us being updated on studies matter.



Aisha NIYODUSABA

COVID-19 stops our studies





VISION SHATTERED

It was declared that the schools have to be locked down because of Covid-19, I couldn't understand why my first exam was canceled the next day. Can you imagine how far I was unhappy with this news because of the way I was well prepared for it? So far schools will reopen in September. I was shaken but I accepted the situation. My mom's shop had closed the same day, my older brother's contract got terminated and my sister's job went on hold! Do you imagine how far getting food was not easy? Everything became hard in short time; I apprehended that my vision was shattered.

Before long the government offered food to us but it was not enough nonetheless it was better than dying hungry. There is no permanent situation, well along things have been reopened, I got a temporary job in a company which makes and sells face masks. Today, I am able to earn some money which makes my days go by. No one is immune to this virus, together we can avoid and stop the spread of Covid-19.

Jean de Dieu TWAHIRWA

Government and friends provide food to us





HOME, A SAFE PLACE

In 2020 March, the Ministry of Education ordered all schools to shut down until unknown time. The announcement was published when I was at school in another district far from home. It was my first time to hear about pandemic disease. Parents had to go pick their children who have been studying in boarding school meanwhile public and private transports offered assistance to transport students across the country.

My dad came to pick me at school on Sunday; he brought for me some protective masks and gloves to wear. Everything was quite dreadful when I reached home. I couldn't grasp the idea that everything was going to be closed in order to prevent the spread of corona virus. I worried how people will survive without working because some people have to work regularly to support their family.

Nowadays I am at home, I can't even visit my friends or family. However, I am able to spend more time with my parents and siblings because we are all at home. I am learning many things from my siblings, I also revising my lessons. I thank Club Rafiki for the safety information they provide to me about Covid-19.

Dinah UMWALI

**STAY HOME,
STAY SAFE!**





INTRODUCTION TO VIRTUAL CLASSES

When the outbreak of covid-19 became obvious lives were threatened, Government across the world adopted new strategies and measures to keep at bay this devastating virus. A state of emergency made all corners of life interrupted including schools in Rwanda; hence Rwanda education board introduced lesson programs on TVs, radios and other different options to conduct class session for diverse levels. I feel blessed with those given lessons which provide me the opportunity to keep myself updating on different subjects.

Timeframe of lessons challenges me, my parents are not facilitating me in some subjects especially those which are in English language because their educational levels are low. Yet I give my class session a top priority and it doesn't stop me for helping my family in other housework.

Waffa UWIKUNDA



why our parents can't help us?

???



LIFE CHANGE



I was at school when the first case of covid-19 was confirmed in my country, most activities were closed as an approach of escaping the spread of Covid-19 within the period of lockdown, I felt as I was punished.

How can people stay indoors for such long period? How will we survive? I wondered! The parents we depended on couldn't work! Our live standard was changed; we weren't able to afford everything we use to buy at all.

Stay at home all day was so challenging to me but I had to cope-up, on other side I enjoy spend time with my family although we don't get whatever we usually used to. Beside all this, there is an improvement on my cooking skills because I am learning how to prepare new dishes.



Josiane UWAMARIYA



When will I back at school?
I miss my classmate





UNFORGETTABLE MOMENTS

We had a recent assemble at school, our Headmaster gave us a new strict rules of not having any contact with the outsiders. I was deeply happy as soon as I perceived the announcement but at time I didn't realize how serious the situation was, all I thought was about coming back to my family because I didn't believe to see them soon.

There were instructions of not hugging each other, not shaking hands, respect of social distance among people. Those instructions came along with Covid-19 were hard both to me and to my younger sister but we followed because it could protect us. There were no more going outside without a justified purpose. Foods at the market became so expensive, but as a child all I could enjoy is to spend more time with my family without going to school.

Until now covid-19 is still in my country, the government has implemented some regulations to avoid the spread of the virus. Above all I thank to my parents for guiding me, I appreciate how Club Rafiki become my second parents.

Marie Aimee IZERE



REMEMBER THE DAYS

Truly I keep remembering the days in lockdown when our life as human beings was threatened by the pandemic of Covi-19, we were not used to stay at home from Monday to Sunday. Everyone was supposed to stay at home in order to stay safe and healthy. As young generation, Covid-19 was a dangerous virus that brought a terrible situation I have never experienced in my life.

At the beginning I thought it was rumors but after it kills hundreds a day in certain countries, thus I saw that it was no longer rumors. I was removed from my school in hurry and my studies was ruined by lockdown. Most entertaining activities were closed but it was for our own safety. I remember just how this lockdown destroyed the side of trade among countries, it affected my family also because my father is a driver and it led us to a financial crisis at home.

I would like to acknowledge the effort of doctors who take the risk and try their best to save lives of many people who were exposed to covid19. I thank also Club Rafiki as my inspiring place.

Abdoul Djalibu NIYONKURU

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AWFUL SITUATION

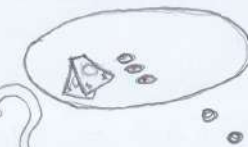
We faced resilient time when we stopped working due to Covid-19, life became completely unbearable. We started going hungry for days without food.

Then my mother agreed with our neighbor to bring whatever food they had so that we could add other ingredients in order to have something to put in our stomachs. We decided to have a common kitchen to see if those days would go well. Before Lockdown, we could have enjoyed two course meals per day; it was a luxury which we could not afford due to covid-19.

Even though things didn't yet become normal like it used to be before, I see some improvement, life became bearable, many families felt relieved when Lockdown was lifted, hope was materialized in community.

Naira UWIMANA

Mom, I am hungry,
give me food please.



UNWANTED HOLIDAYS

I am a fashion model who is commonly known as a supermodel. I usually do some freelance jobs in fashion industry, even if most of them were temporally, they kept me going alive.

When corona virus was manifested in Rwanda, I had an appointment of shooting some pictures of an agency fashion house. I had already planned for that money I could have earn, Unfortunately the planned show become unreal due to Covid-19, I got unwanted holidays and I was sleeping hungry because I was no longer working, My bank account was empty. Who can I blame? None! Many people was starving and all were locked. I was asking myself why we were passing through this pain! Does God forgot us?

There is still hope, I can see today light through darkness and thanks to everyone for the spent efforts to stop the spread of this pandemic. Big thanks to my country, to beloved English corner for its inspiration and the opportunity to share my lockdown experience via this book.

Danny TUIYISHIME



*I have only two coins
in my pocket*



BROKENHEARTED

My name is christel; I'm 16 years old girl who used to be enthusiastic about education and happy time especially when spending those wonderful moment surrounded with my family, I was born in a family of two boys and one girl which mean that I'm an only girl in my family. I had a very loving parents who raised us in a proper way, attending nice school, during holidays we used to visit relatives in country side especially my grandmother who lived sixty miles from home in Kigali, briefly my father was the owner of a media company and it was a successful business to point he never want my mother to go working because he could have provided for all our needs, my mother role was to take good care of us and see to family welfare.

I remember when I used to go to my office and seat with him watch others workers in that big room sitting in front of their desk and from time to time one would come at the door and show my father some report to me it was a sense of power, unfortunately when I was 13 years my father get sick and passed away, it was a shocking new to all of us but my mother tried to comfort us by promise that she will take good care of us, well the loss we experienced wasn't actually financial but emotional , my mother inherited the business and continued to run it. Like that was not enough pain already for us, recently we in march after three years we heard about a virus called Covid-19, to me it was like something for others, none of my concern, even though we experienced many changes but it wasn't so bad because our mother did our best to provide for us, yet school was closed and many joyful activities but life was still going on until one day my mother felt sick and our uncle rush her to hospital but a week later she passed away and people in the neighborhood after funeral start to guess what will happen to us .

until today I didn't recollect myself for losing both two parents in a space of three years especially in this period when we need our parent care its grieving me so badly. The only bad memory is when I go with my uncle to my father business and looking at his former office I feel life is mot fair and I'm not sure anymore about the future.

Christel MUTONI





MY HAPPY DAYS

Before the outburst of Covid-19, I was living a happy life with my family, during the weekend we used to visit places around our beautiful city of Kigali and having fun, it was really my happiest period in my entire life as a teenager, I had no worry of anything's. Life was fun especially during school holidays when we will set up an appointment with our school mate to meet in town and do window shopping around the city and while tired seat at a cafeteria having a pizza or cool drink, wow that was life back then until when this devastating virus come into existence and change all our life routine.

Everything was closed especially during the period of lockdown, no unnecessary traveling with a valuable reason, so many restriction entered in to action and beside that, people started to worry and being afraid about their own safety, many family was broken due to effect of the pandemic and my biggest chock was that the whole city was empty like an abandoned or a desolate place.

Life become so frustrating and while certain restriction were lifted life never become normal again. It become obvious that the threat of the pandemic was still in existence and in order to stay alive and avoid the spread of the pandemic people have to respect some regulation such as , wearing a mask, respecting social distance, washing your hands every now and then even avoid to hug your friends or beloved one.

Gone is those day we used to breath clean fresh air and being cozy with your friends and until today we don't know yet what the future is holding for us.

Josette UWONKUNDA



